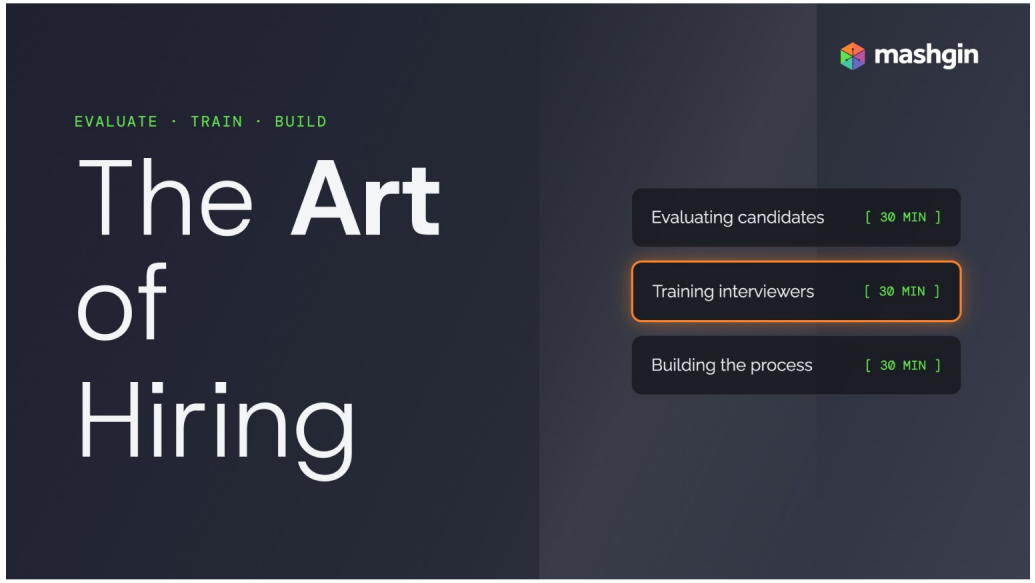
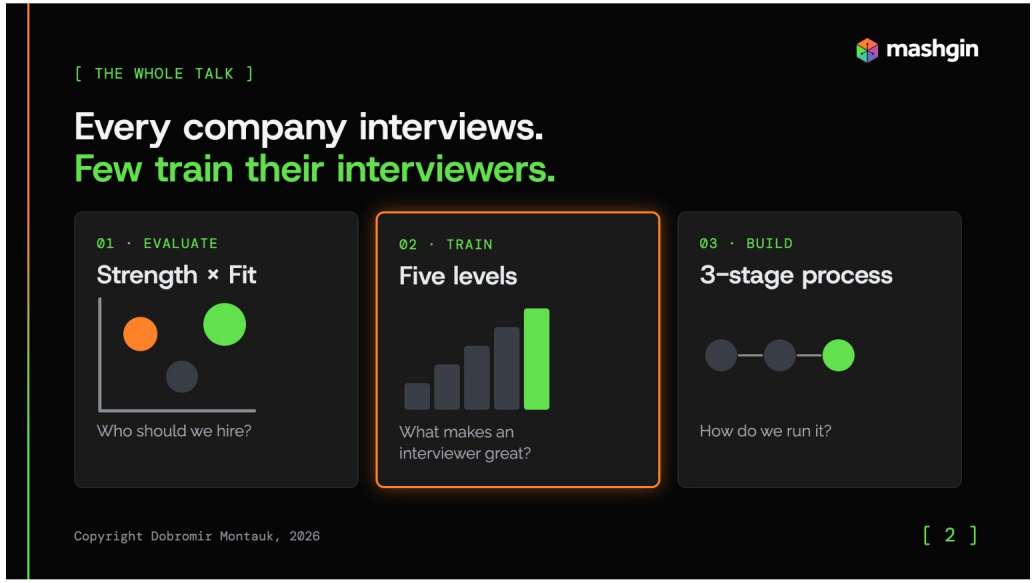


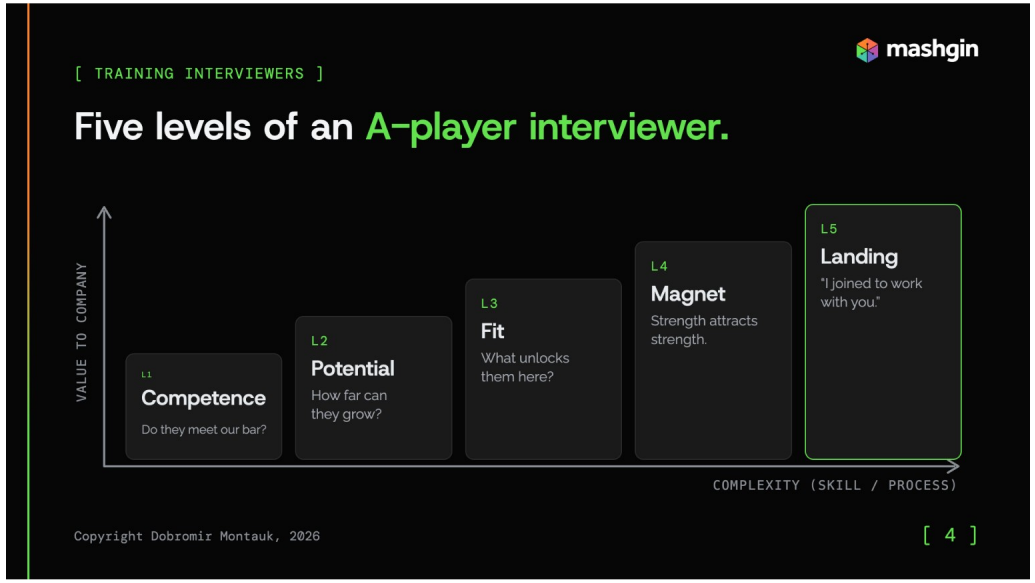
Philosophy, content and process borrowed heavily from TellApart, Twitter, Wade Chambers, and "Who: The A Method for Hiring". Three arcs, about 30 minutes each.



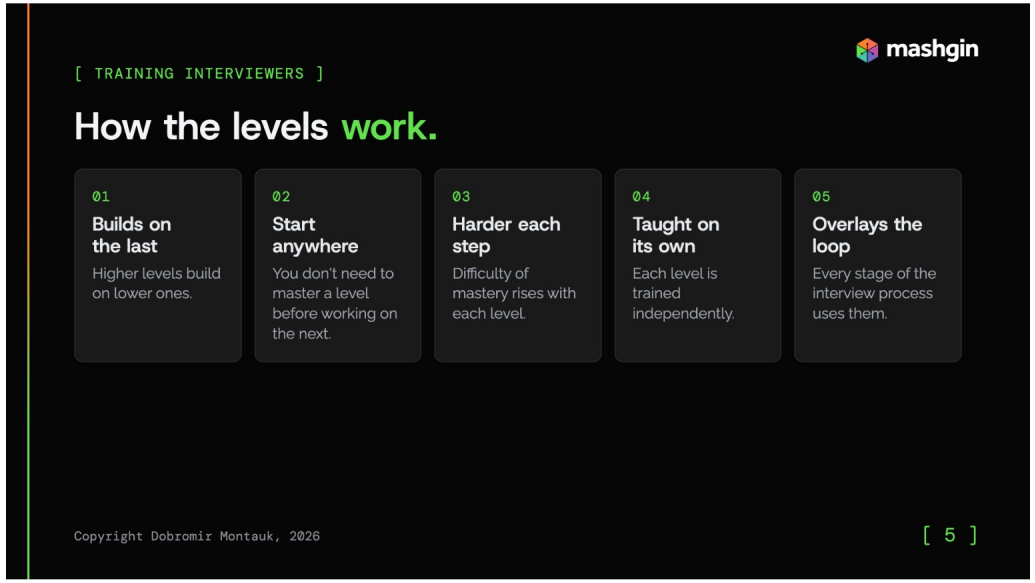
The whole talk on one slide. Arc 1: how we evaluate candidates, on two axes: Strength and Fit. Arc 2: how we train interviewers, through five levels from Competence to Landing. Arc 3: how we build the process, in three stages: getting to the interview, the interview, the close. Philosophy, content and process borrowed heavily from TellApart, Twitter, Wade Chambers, and "Who: The A Method for Hiring".



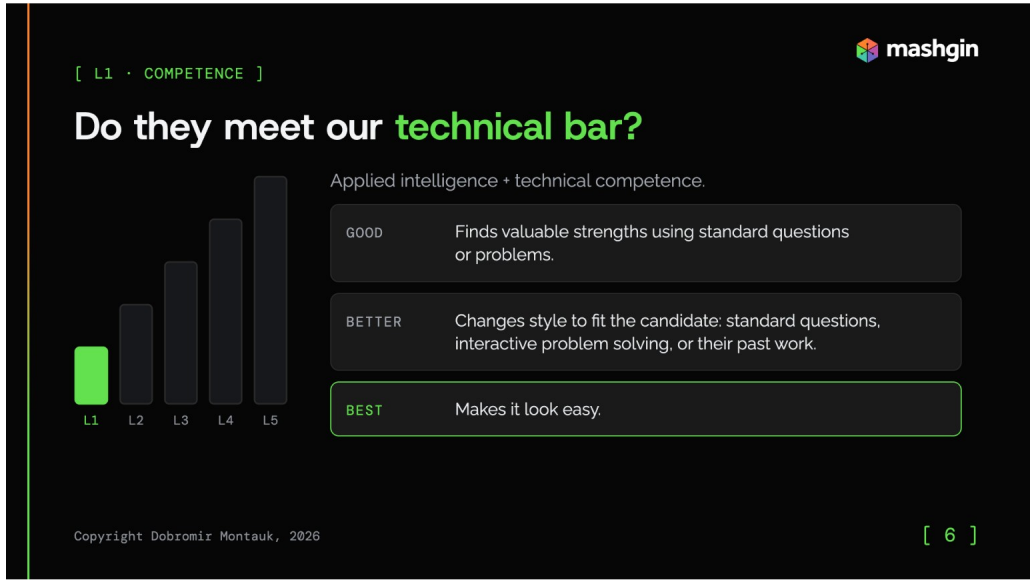
Your job as an Engineering Manager is to BUILD the hiring process, which requires training your interviewers. Arc 1 was who to hire. Arc 2 is how each interviewer gets great at finding and landing them.



The five levels: Competence, Potential, Fit, Magnet, Landing. Each one is more complex to master (skill and process) and more valuable to the company. Most interviewers live at L1. The goal is an interviewer who works all five.



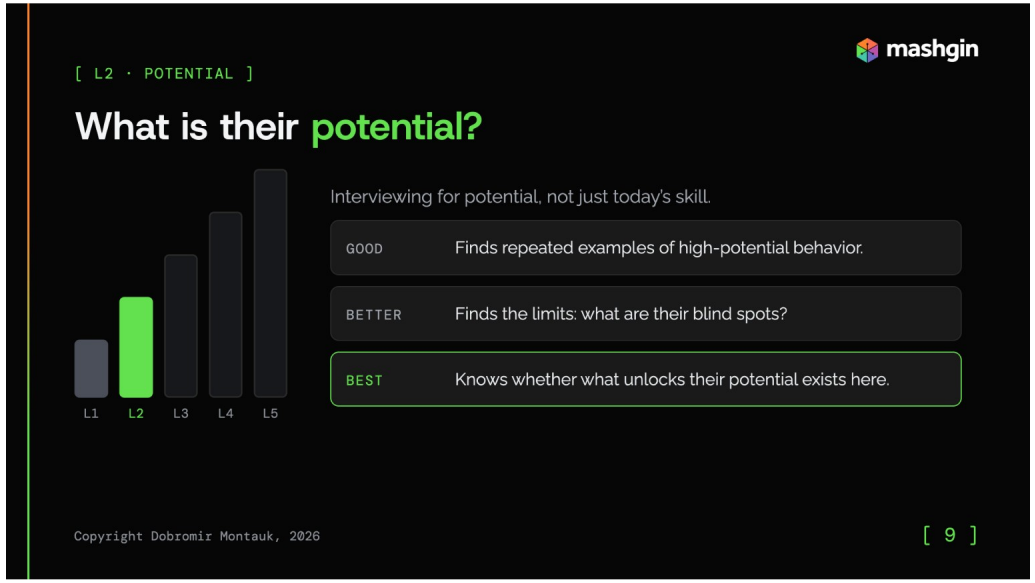
Higher levels build on lower levels. Mastery of a lower level is not required to start working on higher levels. Difficulty in mastery increases with level. Each level is taught independently. And the levels overlay the interview process: every stage uses them.



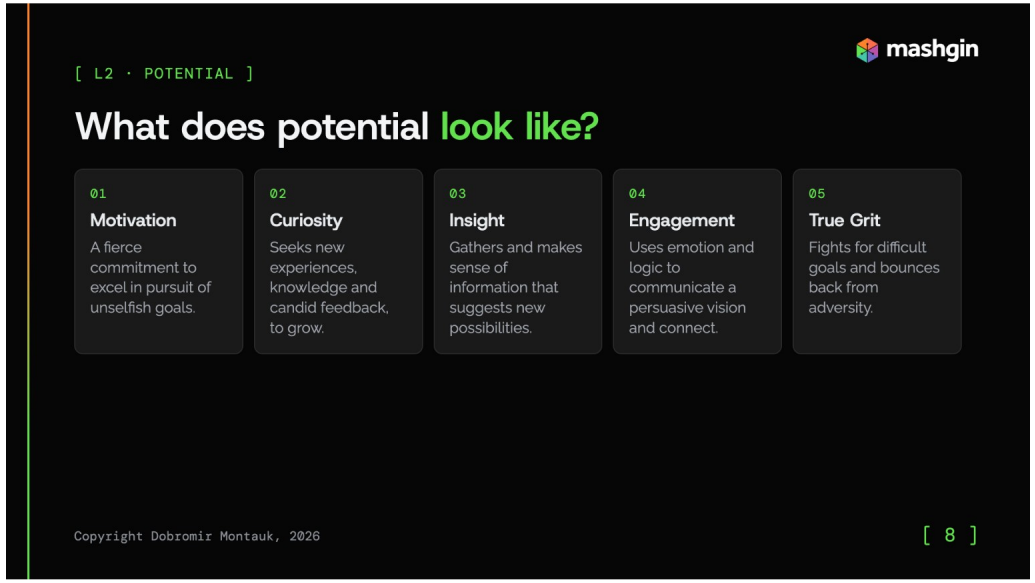
L1, Competence. Question: do they meet our technical bar? Two things: applied intelligence and technical competence. Good: able to find valuable strength(s) using standard questions/problems. Better: able to change styles based on the candidate (standard questions vs. interactive problem solving vs. interviewing using their past). Best: make it look easy. It gets much harder to evaluate at higher levels of seniority.



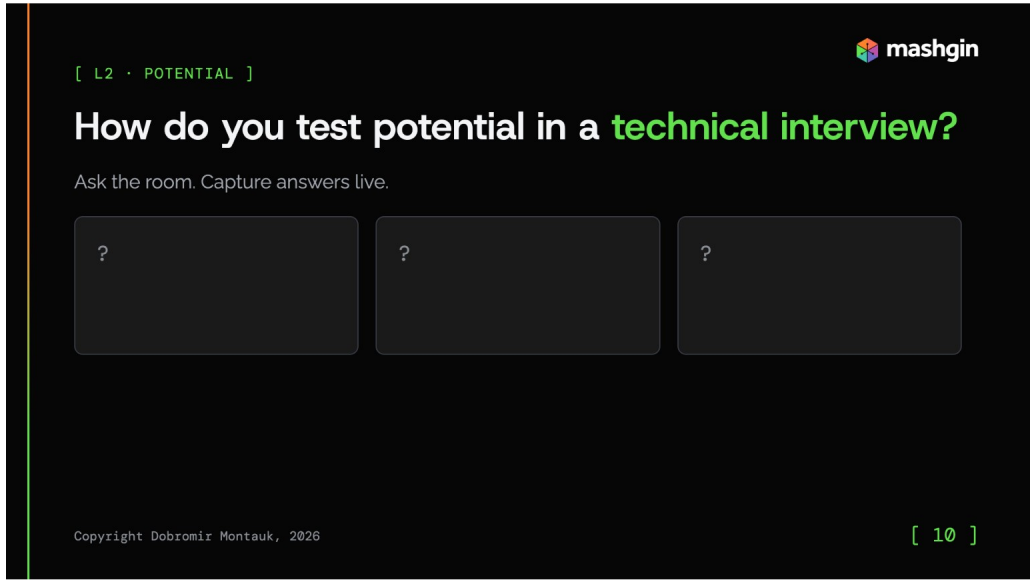
How do you determine senior level? It is not "do they know what I know": knowledge is based on experience, so it is not directly comparable. You need to understand what they SHOULD know based on their résumé and experience. Look for judgment, good questions, improvisation. [Clip from The Matrix: TBD.]



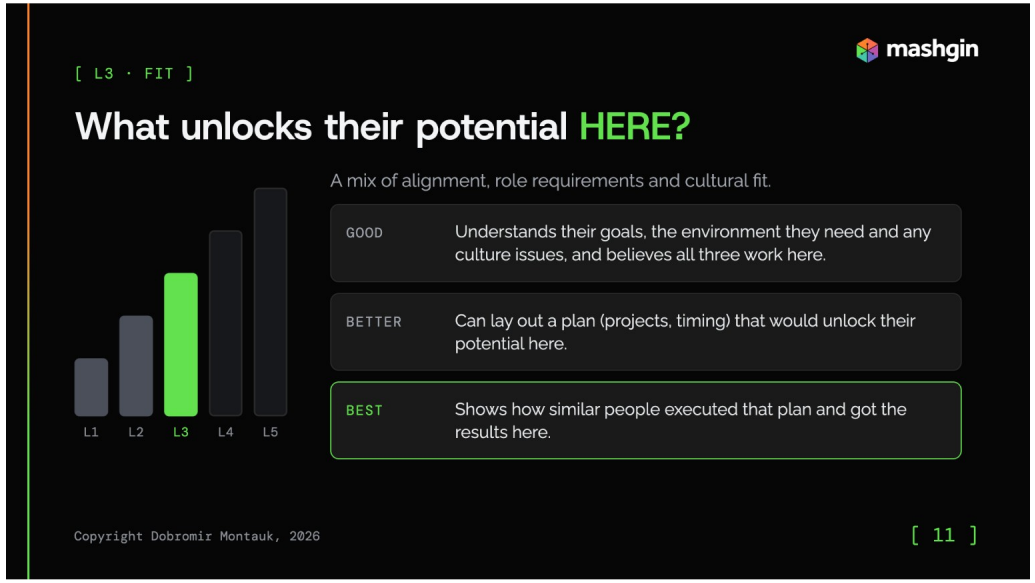
L2, Potential. Good: able to find repeated examples of high-potential behaviors (motivation, curiosity, insight, engagement, determination). Better: able to determine limitations in those behaviors: what are their blind spots? Best: able to correctly determine whether the things necessary to unlock their potential exist here. That last one is the bridge to L3.



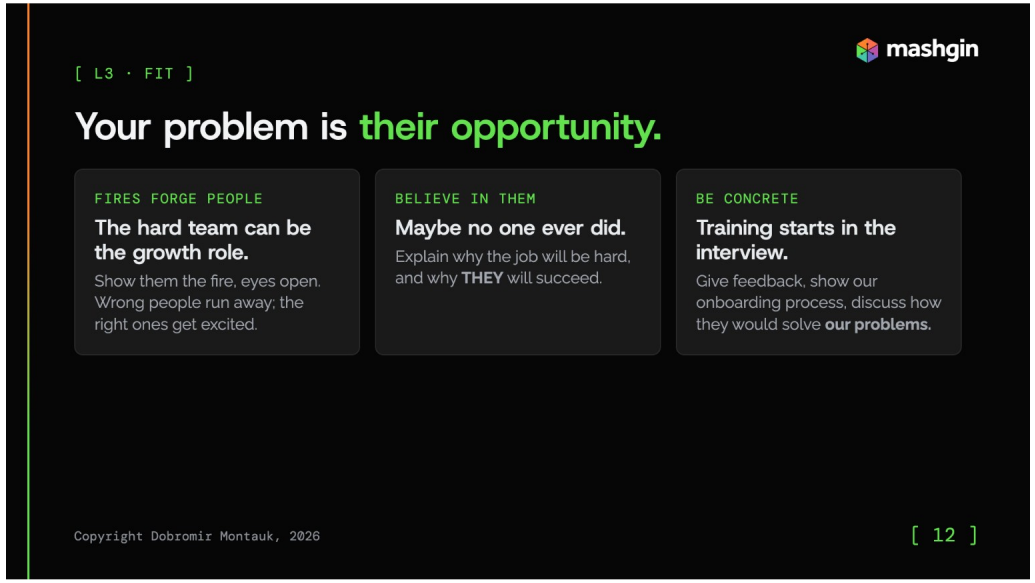
Five high-potential traits. Motivation: a fierce commitment to excel in the pursuit of unselfish goals. Curiosity: seeks new experiences, knowledge, and candid feedback, with a focus on growing. Insight: the ability to gather and make sense of information that suggests new possibilities. Engagement: a knack for using emotion and logic to communicate a persuasive vision and connect with people. Determination: the wherewithal to fight for difficult goals despite challenges, and to bounce back from adversity. (These five come from Claudio Fernández-Aráoz, "21st-Century Talent Spotting", HBR 2014.)



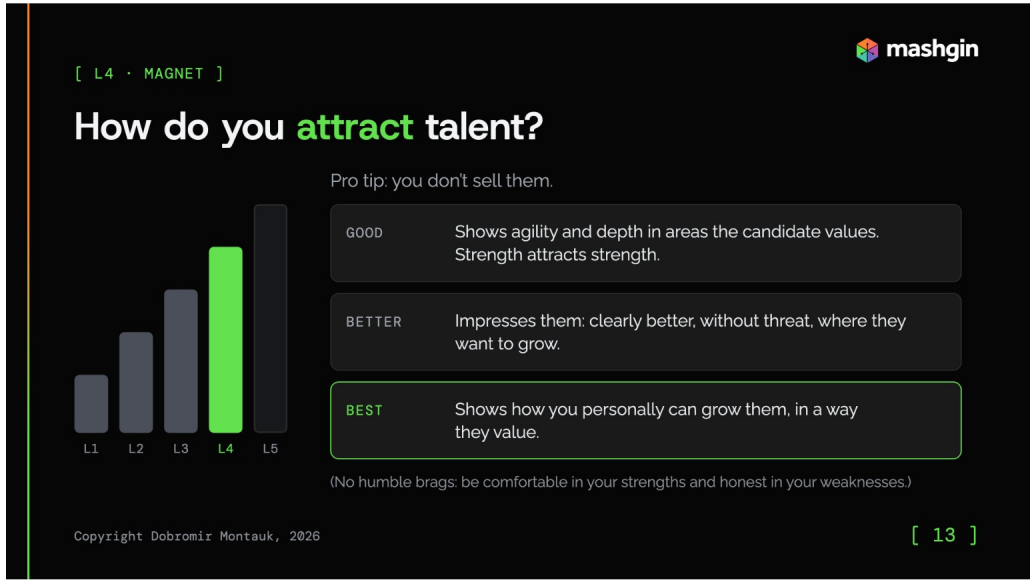
Open question to the room: how do you test for potential inside a technical interview? Capture answers live, on the slide or a whiteboard.



L3, Fit. What unlocks their potential HERE? It's a mix of alignment, role requirements and cultural fit. Good: understand their goals and believe they can achieve them here; understand the environment needed to unlock their potential and believe it exists here; understand cultural fit issues here. Better: able to create a plan (projects and timing) that would unlock their potential here. Best: able to show how a similar candidate's execution against that plan resulted in the desired performance here.



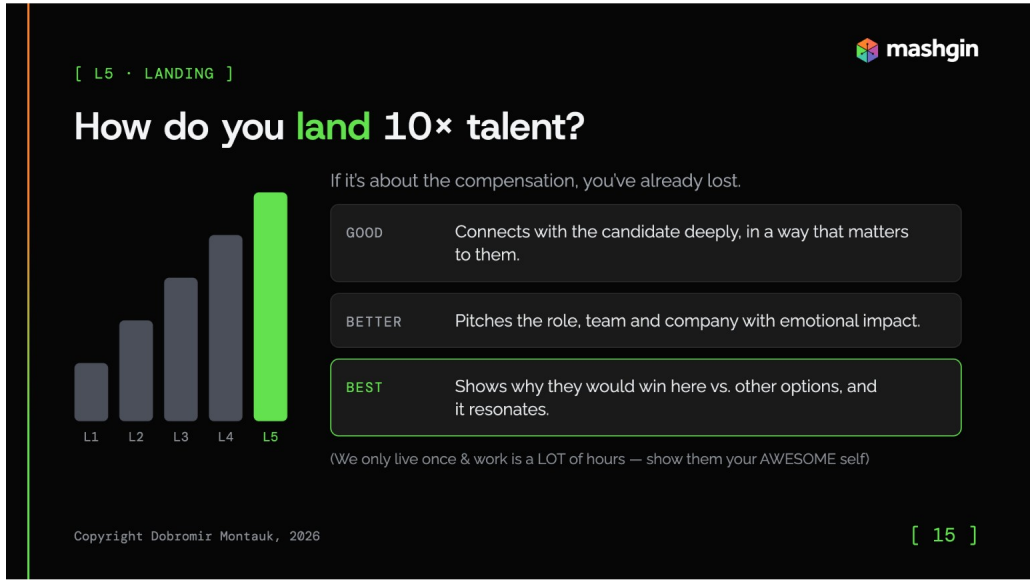
Fit: your problem is their opportunity. Fires forge people: a team in trouble can be the best place to grow. Show them the fire with eyes open; the wrong people run away, the right ones get excited. Believe in them: maybe no one ever did. Explain why the job will be hard, and why THEY will succeed. Be concrete: training starts during the interview. Give feedback, show our onboarding process, and discuss how they would solve our problems.



L4, Magnet. How do you attract talent? Pro tip: you don't sell them. Good: able to demonstrate agility and depth in areas the candidate values (strength attracts strength). Better: able to impress the candidate: clearly better, in a non-threatening way, in key areas where the candidate wants to grow. Best: able to demonstrate how you personally can grow the candidate in a way the candidate values ("we can grow you"). No humble brags: be comfortable in your strengths and honest in your weaknesses.



Strength attracts strength. Leaders want to work for leaders stronger than themselves. You know you have B players when they feel uncomfortable with A players. You know you have C players when they can't tell the difference between A and C players. Your interviewers ARE the pitch.



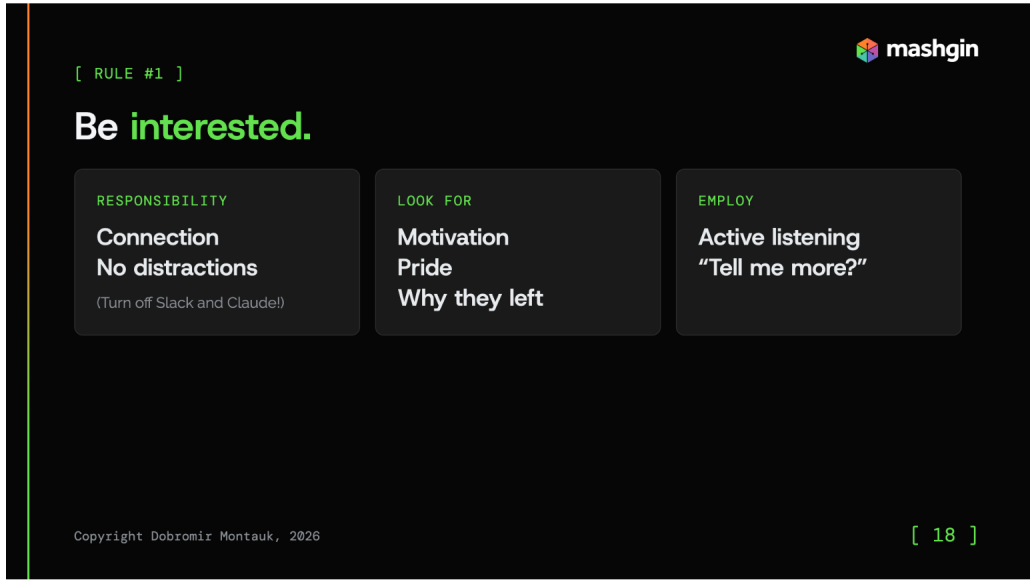
L5, Landing. How do you land 10x talent? If it's about the compensation, you've already lost. Good: able to deeply connect with the candidate in a way that is meaningful to them. Better: able to pitch the value of the role/team/org/company in a way that has emotional impact. Best: able to show them why they would win here vs. other options, and have it resonate. We only live once, and work is a LOT of hours: show them your AWESOME self.



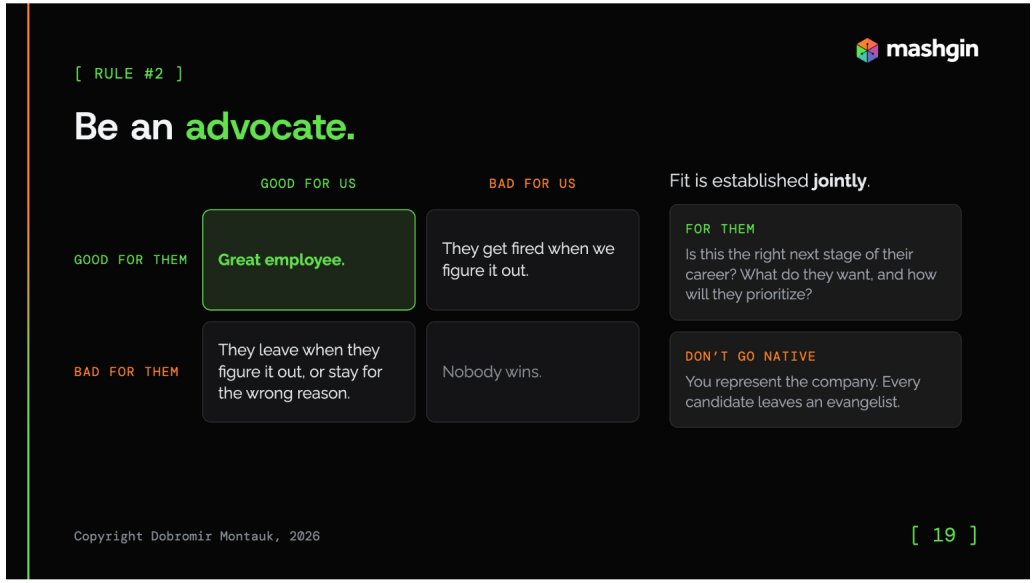
When you start hearing "I joined this company to work with you", you are at L5. People ultimately make decisions for emotional reasons, and come up with the rational ones to back them up. That's not a bad thing: emotion is very high-order computation. So tap into it. Show them you understand what pulls on their heartstrings, and why, by joining us, this won't be a JOB.



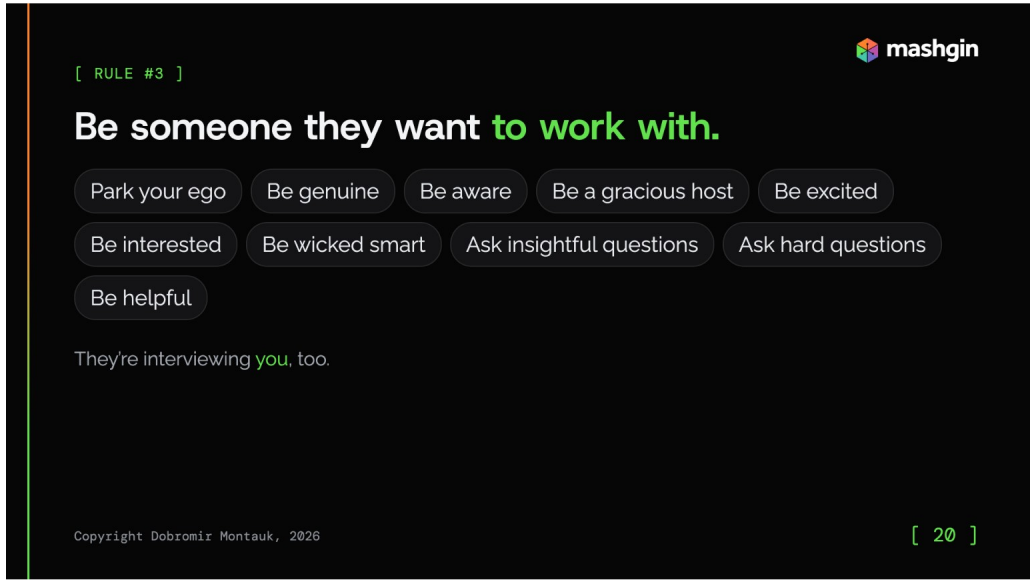
Put together, the five levels make an A-player interviewer. Next: three rules that make every level work.



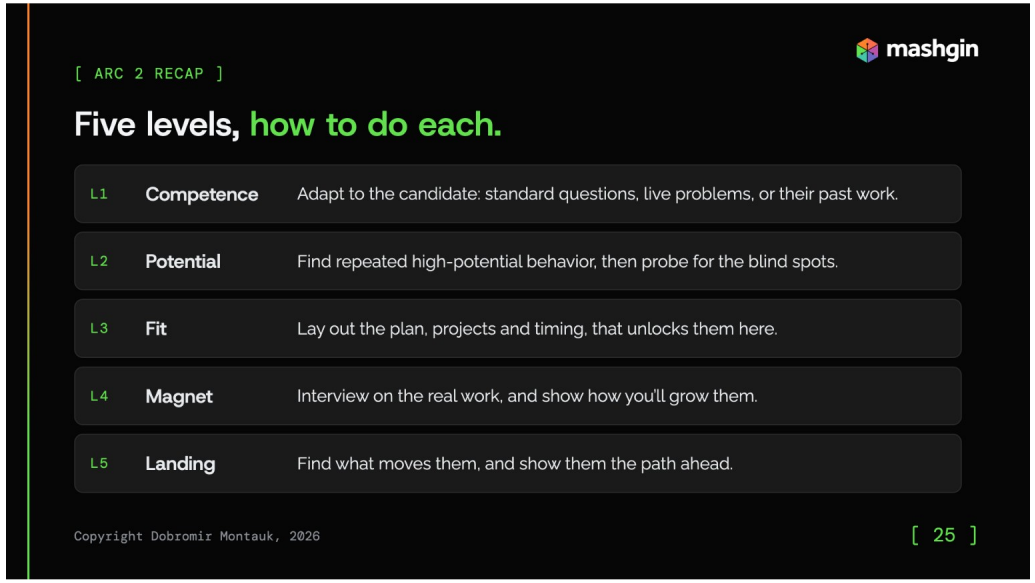
Rule #1: be interested. Take responsibility for being interested: create connection, leave distractions outside the room (turn off Slack and Claude!), lower barriers to effective communication, make the candidate want to expand on details. Look for: what motivates them, what demotivates them, excitement and interest points, fear and pain points, their level of technical, personal and social skill, what they are proud of, why they took a role, why they left it. Employ active listening and curiosity: "what?", "how?", "tell me more?"



Rule #2: be an advocate. Fit needs to be jointly established. Good for them and good for us: great employee. Good for us, bad for them: they leave when they figure it out, or stay for the wrong reason. Good for them, bad for us: they get fired when we figure it out. For them: is this a good place for the next stage of their career? What are they looking for? How will they prioritize? Do they have clarity on what they want and need? Within reason, help them figure out fit ("this could mean this or that, which did you mean?", "here is what I learned about you"). Don't set them up for failure. Don't go native: remember you represent the company. We always want candidates to leave as company evangelists. For us: is this an A player?



Rule #3: be someone they want to work with. Park your ego. Be genuine. Be aware. Be a gracious host. Be excited. Be interested. Be wicked smart. Ask insightful questions. Ask hard questions. Be helpful.



Recap: the five levels, and how to do each. L1 Competence: Adapt to the candidate: standard questions, live problems, or their past work. L2 Potential: Find repeated high-potential behavior, then probe for the blind spots. L3 Fit: Lay out the plan, projects and timing, that unlocks them here. L4 Magnet: Interview on the real work, and show how you'll grow them. L5 Landing: Find what moves them, and show them the path ahead. Next, Arc 3: building the process.